Feedback on the Project Proposals

Here is a summary of recurring issues through the project proposals.

1. Determine the data from the question

The workflow should be:

1. Start from one precise question.
2. Then identify the variables you need to answer it.
3. Only then decide which data sources you will collect.

Several projects present a global theme or question, then a collection of datasets that are not necessarily tied to the question. Ask yourself: "If I remove one of my proposed datasets, does my main question become impossible to answer?" If the answer is no, then the dataset is not necessary.

Oftentimes, this is present in the proposal because you add other aspects, additional platforms, or another collection process. The main issue here is having a lot of unnecessary data.

2. Narrow the project to a coherent investigation

Several projects have a semi-undefined central question followed by multiple precise sub-questions. While you will probably need several analyses to answer your initial question, they should all try to solve the same goal. While it is fine to have several ideas to investigate currently, you should aim to narrow the investigation to ensure you collect the relevant data to answer that question (this is, in some way, connected to the first point).

3. Precise the operationalization of the collection.

As we saw in Session 3, there are several ways to turn a concept into a measure. Yet several of your proposals use concepts from an intuitive perspective but do not (yet) operationalize them, e.g., "safe", "success", "popular", "generic", "failure". If two members of your group could reasonably calculate a variable differently, you haven't defined it precisely enough yet. You should be able to clarify exactly what it is, how it is calculated, and from what raw data.

4. Do not confuse "more data" with "better project"

Several proposals are already heading toward a potentially enormous amount of data or many external sources. The objective is not to collect the maximum amount of data, but to collect the data necessary to answer your question well.

5. Do not promise sophisticated analysis before understanding the data

This might be a byproduct of using LLM to help you write the proposal. Still, several projects already mention quite precise analysis methods. Remember not to choose it simply because it sounds appropriate: you will first need to establish what your data can support.

As several groups have already pointed out, the next step is to validate your collection method to assess feasibility.